

# COMMUNITY RESPONSE GUIDE AND SAN DIEGO FAMILY CONNECTION HUB

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# WHY WE ARE HERE: SHARED GOALS



Use data and research to collectively unpack systemic challenges; continuous quality improvement (CQI) post-implementation



Design an intervention to support reporting that is more consistent, accurate, and equitable.



Support child safety and family needs on a continuum, as a partnership across systems.



Help reduce unnecessary system intervention for families whose needs do not warrant a CPS investigation, which allows CPS to focus its resources on responding to concerns that require a response.

# COMMUNITY RESPONSE GUIDE PROJECT PHASES

## Planning

Create  
core team

Vision and  
values

Theory of  
change

## Discovery

Explore  
mandated  
reporter  
practice and  
policy

Community  
Kickoff

## Design

Workgroup  
tool design

Test tool

## Implement

Implementation  
plan

Web-based  
pilot tool

## Evaluate

Evaluation  
CQI

# SAN DIEGO FINDINGS PREVIEW

- Only half (51%) of reports made to the County of San Diego CWS hotline are screened in by CWS.
- Most reports are made by mandated reporters.
- General neglect is the most common allegation reported (44%).
- Both overreporting and underreporting practices are occurring.
- Racial disproportionality begins at the decision to report.
- Families, reporters, CWS, and prevention partners face dilemmas and challenges with current mandated reporting practices.

# INEFFICIENCY AND OVERREPORTING

4.4M referrals involving  
**7.8M** children of suspected  
maltreatment nationwide

Screened  
Out  
53%

Screened  
In  
48%

3.1M children in  
screened-in reports

Substantiation Findings

Abused or  
Neglected

546K

Not Abused or Neglected

2.54M

Services Received

300K

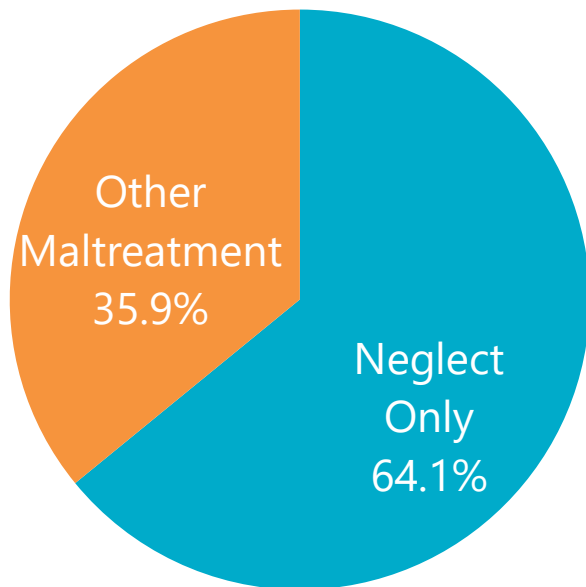
590K

Source: Children's Bureau, 2023

**EVIDENT  
CHANGE**

# NEGLECT AND POVERTY IN CHILD WELFARE

## Confirmed Maltreatment Cases in 2023



Source: Children's Bureau, 2024, 2025

## Economic Hardship in Child Welfare



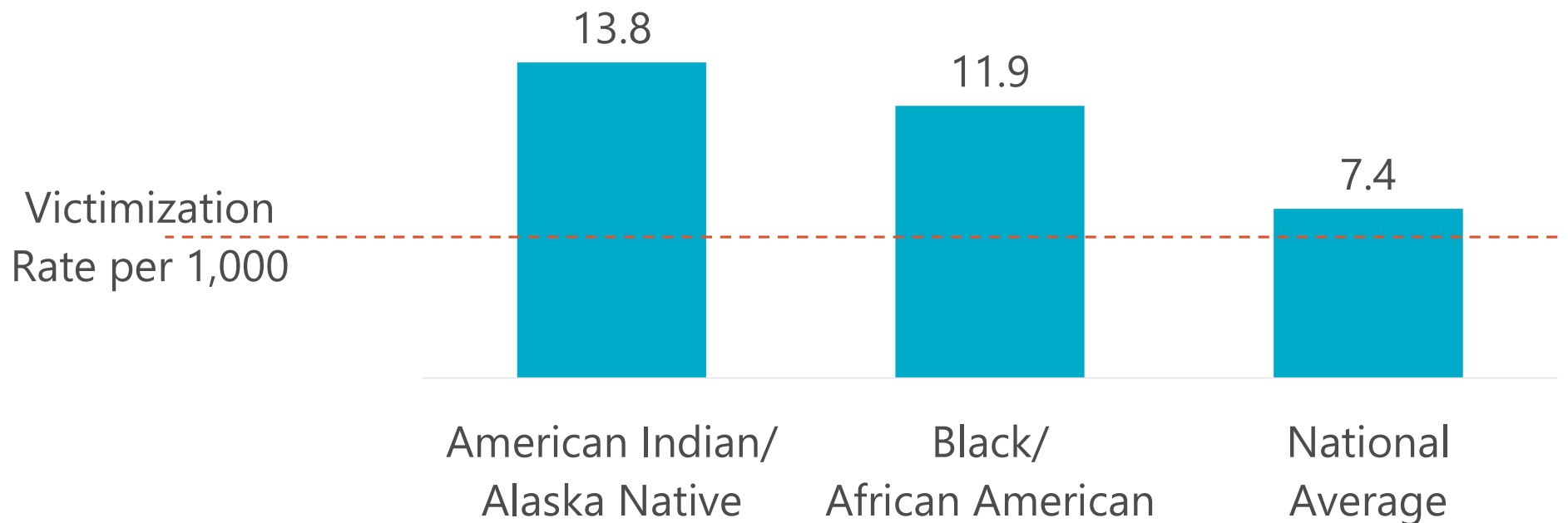
83%

Most families in the child welfare system are struggling with economic hardship.

Poverty is a key driver in child welfare involvement.

Sources: Anderson et al., 2024; Casanueva et al., 2024; Kim & Drake, 2023; Children's Bureau 2023

# RACIAL DISPARITIES IN SUBSTANTIATION RATES





# CHALLENGES WITH THE CURRENT SYSTEM

- Inconsistent mandated reporting practices
- Significant impact on families
- Confused and overburdened reporters
- System overload
- Fear-driven reporting culture



# THE COMMUNITY RESPONSE GUIDE ...

- Is a web-based decision-support tool.
- Guides professional reporters and concerned community members about reporting and alternative supports.
- Is designed through a data-driven, **community-based** workgroup process.
- Becomes a **community intervention** through the design process itself.

# BRINGING THE BEST OF DECISION SUPPORT TO THE REPORTING DECISION



**Equity**



**Accuracy**



**Consistency**



**Utility**

# SAN DIEGO CRG INCREASES ACCURACY IN DECISIONS



N = 323

# RECOMMENDATIONS

## Report Not Required

Continue relationship with child and family.  
Provide support where appropriate.

## Community Support Pathway

Connect the family with community-based resources.

## Report

Make an immediate report to CPS.

# COMMUNITY SUPPORT PATHWAY (CSP)

A CSP provides communities with tangible support by:

- **Assisting mandated reporters** in understanding their role in supporting child safety outside of child protection;
- **Connecting children and families** to local support services that may be better suited to address their needs; and
- **Building reliable support networks** for long-term family well-being and child safety within their communities.

# WHAT DOES THIS LOOK LIKE IN PRACTICE?



# GOALS OF FAMILY CONNECTION HUB



Ensure a prevention-focused infrastructure to safely keep children at home using a full array of prevention services, including evidence-based practices.



Eliminate income criteria, creating opportunities to provide prevention services to all families.

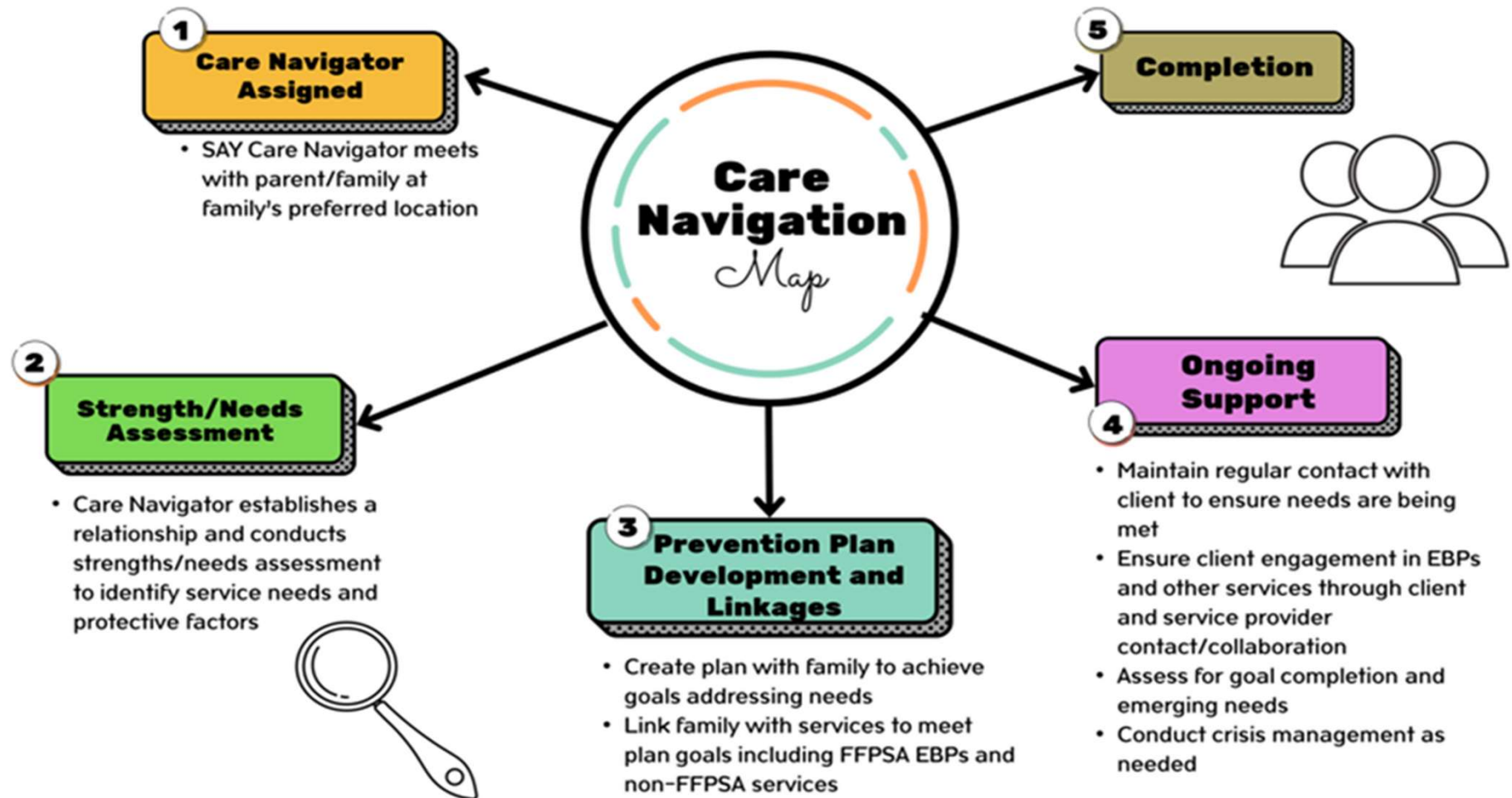


Provide funding to support services to prevent the entry or return of youth into foster care or probation systems.



Create a community-based access point to guide and support families through the prevention pathway.

# FAMILY CONNECTION HUB: FAMILY'S EXPERIENCE





# QUESTIONS?

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